

Lesson 8: Listening to Lead

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As a coach, Pat Summitt was known for her commanding tone and strong leadership style. But did you know that she also spent a lot of time learning to listen? Listening well is one of the best kept secrets to being a leader. How many of us go through a day without saying a word? None of us. But maybe we ought to try it, she once said. Communicating is not just about giving great speeches, it's about allowing others to express themselves. If a championship coach like Pat Summitt can take the time to slow down and listen to those she was leading, you can too.

One of the things that I have learned over the years, especially being a married man, is that there is a reason why we have two ears and one mouth. That means that we should listen twice as much as we should speak. For me, that has really resonated a great deal because as an effective leader, I want to make sure that I listen to everyone that I lead. Again, there is a difference between hearing and listening. Actively listening means that you are paying attention to what is being said, and you ingest what is being said, thus making you a more impactful leader.

So, as I work every single day, I make sure that I put the needs of others before myself, especially when it comes to operating in the highest capacity. That means that I'm listening, I'm actively listening instead of just thinking of the next thing to say. As a leader, your ability to listen actively and sympathetically plays a significant role in encouraging a positive work environment, promoting collaboration, and ultimately achieving success. Listening is the foundation of building trust and respect on your team.

When you actively listen to your employees, they feel value and it creates a sense of psychological safety. Take the time to engage in open conversations where employees feel comfortable expressing their thoughts and concerns. By valuing their feedback, you are demonstrating that their contributions matter to the team. Rather than simply having everyone feel heard, understanding your team's needs and concerns is essential for having the knowledge to effectively address potential issues proactively as a leader.

And how you listen is just as important as the act of listening itself. No lesson on communication would be complete without a closer look at this important topic. So, take a breath and let's learn more on how you can become an active listener in the workplace.